

Ecocycle Planning

For Scrum
Teams

**The
Liberators**

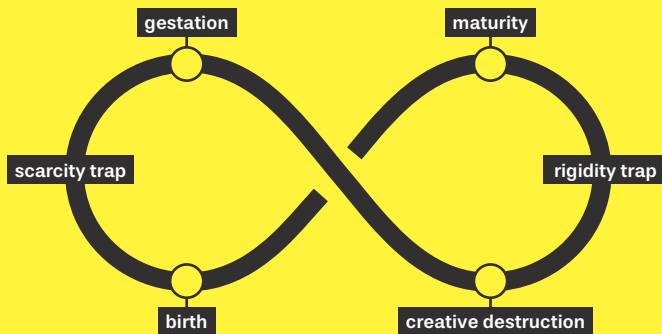
An abstract geometric design featuring large, overlapping semi-circles and triangles in orange and light gray, separated by thick dark gray outlines. The design is contained within a dark gray rectangular frame.

Diagnose your Scrum Team with Ecocycle Planning

The first step towards recovery from Zombie Scrum is to recognize whether it's there or not. The purpose of this experiment is to create transparency around what your Scrum Team is currently doing, and how elements of Zombie Scrum may show through.

Background

Ecocycle Planning is part of the repertoire of Liberating Structures*. Its purpose is to analyze the full portfolio of activities and identify obstacles and opportunities for progress in a markedly non-linear way. That makes it an excellent way to periodically reflect on your work together and to decide what to focus on next. It is based on the life cycle in nature, as shown below:



The activities of your Scrum Team can be plotted on an Ecocycle as follows:

- **Gestation** represents all the activities that you think would be useful to you as a team, but that you are not doing at the moment.
- **Birth** represents the activities that you have just started doing as a team, or that you've been investing in. Although they are not fully valuable yet, and probably take effort and discipline to do, they will become increasingly valuable as you keep doing them.
- **Maturity** represents the activities that are comfortable and valuable to you as a team. It doesn't take much effort or discipline to do them. It's become part of your rhythm as a Scrum Team.
- **Creative Destruction** represents the activities that have either lost their value to you as a team, or need to be reinvented in order to become useful again. Perhaps by doing it in a different way or from a different perspective. Or you want to stop doing them altogether.

All activities flow through the Ecocycle. But they can also get stuck. Activities that you know are important, but are never invested in, get stuck in the **Scarcity Trap**. Activities that you keep doing, but aren't really adding any value any longer, are in the **Rigidity Trap**. By plotting all your activities across the Ecocycle, you can identify patterns that tell you something about where you are as a team. Look for the following patterns in particular:

- A healthy Ecocycle is balanced. There is innovation taking place, as evidenced by activities on the left of the model, and there are activities that are mature, as evidenced by items on the right. Furthermore, teams are continuously reinventing how to do things and become better, as represented in what is in Creative Destruction.
- Activities that are in the Rigidity Trap and Creative Destruction are prime candidates for reinvention or even removal. Start there before adding new activities, as this creates space for something new.

Skill		This experiment requires some preparation.
Impact on survival		Zombie Scrum is like a vampire. When you shine a light on it, it tends to crumble. This experiment is all about that.

Steps

Prepare for this experiment as follows:

1. Invite your Scrum Team. Instead of requiring people to join, instead clarify the purpose, make a heartfelt appeal for people to join, but leave it to them.
2. Create a large, shared Ecocycle Planning on the floor or the wall.
3. Use the Ecocycle Planning Cards to label the various quadrants of the Ecocycle.
4. Make sure that everyone in your team has a full set of Activity Cards. If you don't have enough, either make copies or put them somewhere visible so people can copy them (or just the unique keys on the cards).
5. Bring empty pieces of paper.

So how do you do this experiment with your team?

1. Introduce Ecocycle Planning. Explain the metaphor, the quadrants and give some examples to help people understand it. It's okay if people don't get it right away; you often have to experience Ecocycle Planning several times to start seeing the possibilities (10 min).
2. Introduce the Activity Cards. Give each person a deck of cards and an empty piece of paper (5 min).
3. Invite people to draw an Ecocycle on their piece of paper. Give them time to silently distribute the activities across their own Ecocycle based on where they think they are for their Scrum Team (15 min).
4. Invite everyone to take their decks and place each activity in the large, shared Ecocycle where they put them on their own Ecocycle (10 min).
5. Invite people to step back and take in the patterns, walking around as needed. Ask them to focus on the items for which there is consensus. Ask "What does the placement of the items say about our ability to ship fast and deliver value to our

- stakeholders? Where do you see connections between the items?" (4 min).
6. Invite people to pair up and share their observations (4 min). Repeat twice more in different pairs. Then, ask people to share the most salient patterns with the whole group. You can help draw out patterns by noticing where most cards of one color appear, whether or not the Ecocycle is balanced and which items appear in the traps (15 min). You may be at risk of Zombie Scrum when a lot of activities are on the left or in the traps.
 7. Invite people to consider the following question in silence for a few minutes: "Which activities do we need to creatively reinvent or expand in order to move forward as a Scrum Team?". Then ask people to pair up and pick the two or three items together (4 min) and then again paired with another pair (10 min). Ask each group of four to share the two or three items they picked (5 min).
 8. Use a Liberating Structure like "Shift & Share", "1-2-4-ALL" or "15% Solutions" to develop action plans to work on the selected items. You can also perform a more thorough debrief with the Liberating Structure "What, So What, Now What".

Our Findings

- When you have a large group of people (8-10 or more), you can also create pairs or small groups of three or four people for steps 4, 5 and 6. We don't recommend larger groups.

- Ecocycle Planning can be done with one Scrum Team, but also with many at the same time. This allows you to see patterns across teams. You can also include stakeholders and management to offer their perspectives.



License

ZombieScrum.org – Find more help at zombiescrum.org. Or get a copy of our book 'The Zombie Scrum Survival Guide'

•All Liberating Structures are created and curated by Keith McCandless and Henri Lipmanowicz. For more information, see liberatingstructures.com

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Created By The Liberators



Barry Overeem, Christiaan Verwijs and Johannes Schartau



Unleashing Organisational Superpowers



GESTATION





BIRTH





MATURITY





CREATIVE DESTRUCTION



SCARCITY TRAP



RIGIDITY TRAP

